

OIL PAINTS



Walnuts



Walnut oil

Walnut oil was more popular in the past than it is today, as it is difficult to keep fresh for any length of time. Walnuts contain about 65% oil.



Poppy seeds



Opium poppy plant

Drying and semidrying oils

The range of drying and semidrying oils used to bind pigments together are made from the crushed and pressed seeds of certain plants. The most important of these plants is linseed oil, which is a golden yellow drying oil and comes from the seeds of the flax plant. The best quality linseed oil is cold-pressed, although most modern oils are hot-pressed. Poppy oil is a semidrying oil made from the seeds of the opium poppy plant. It is a pale straw color and has long been popular as a binding medium for pale pigments that might

be affected by the more yellowing linseed oil. It is popular for alla prima work (see pp.52-52) as it takes a long time to dry. This means that the paint can be moved around for some time after it has been applied. Safflower oil from the seeds of the safflower plant is similarly pale and slow-drying, and it can be used in the same manner as poppy oil. Walnut oil from the nuts of the walnut tree was very popular in the past for its pale color, and it has been identified as a binding medium for white and blue pigments in many Renaissance paintings. It should be used fresh, as it goes rancid quickly.

Traditional and modern oil mixes

In the past, artists used a wide variety of ingredients in their painting mediums (below); some caused pictures to darken and crack. Nowadays, a mix of stand (linseed) oil and turpentine is recommended, and very little resin, if any, should be added.

Sun-bleached linseed oil

Copal oil varnish

Black oil

Orpiment pigment

Realgar pigment

Realgar

Azurite pigment

Azurite

Poppy oil

Poppy seeds contain about 50% oil. This semidrying oil is slow to dry in comparison with drying oils such as linseed oil, so to avoid any cracks appearing, ensure it is completely dry before overpainting.



Traditional pigment sources

Traditional pigments were made from natural sources. The mineral azurite was ground to powder and used as an underlayer for Ultramarine Blue. The red and yellow pigments realgar and orpiment are poisonous and no longer available. Synthetic substances now replace many natural pigments.